plan.[6] He also stresses that there was never a decision to expel the Arabs. In a November 2003 conference on refugees and the "right of return," Morris stated that the displacement of a large part of the population, perhaps even a majority of the 700,000, was not *outside of Palestine* (i.e., the territory of the British Mandate), but *within* it, and that consequently these persons were not refugees according to international norms or law.

Moreover, he argued, their descendants should not be recognized as refugees. From the end of 1947 to May 1948, the bloody clashes were actually a "civil war" initiated by the Arabs against the Jewish community in British Mandate Palestine (the Yishuv). The Jews had the upper hand because they were more willing and determined. Furthermore, the goals set out by most of the Arab leaders when they instigated hostilities in November–December 1947 and when they invaded in May 1948 were to destroy the Jewish state and perhaps even the Yishuv. The Yishuv feared that that the Palestinians, and later the Arab states, would try their hand at producing a Middle Eastern version of the Holocaust, less than three years after the end of World War II. In this context, it should be remembered that one of the most prominent leaders of Palestinian nationalism at that time was Haj Amin al-Husseini, an avowed admirer of Adolf Hitler, who never masked his support for the idea of annihilating the Jewish people. The commander of the "Arab Liberation Army" which fought in the north, Fawzi al-Qawukji, was also sympathetic to the Nazis and lived in Germany for a period during World War II.

Benny Morris explains that the Palestinian refugee problem unfolded over four-and-a-half stages between 1947 and 1950.

The first phase, from the end of November 1947 until the end of March 1948, took place when some one hundred thousand refugees left their homes *voluntarily.* This exile of choice was a continuation of a similar phenomenon that occurred during the Arab Revolt of 1936 to 1939. It should be noted in this context that almost all the members of the Arab Higher Committee were outside of Palestine until March 1948, as was the political leadership of the cities and some of the villages. And when the leadership is absent, the flock scatters. In the closing remarks of his book, in which Morris details the reasons for the Arab flight during the first stage, from November 1947 to March 1948, in which, as mentioned, some one hundred thousand Arab residents left towns and villages that were intended to be part of the State of Israel in accordance with the UN Partition Plan, he